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CLASS, GENDER, AND THE RELATIONS OF DISTRIBUTION

JOAN ACKER

Class and gender discrimination and exploitation are integral to the oppression of women in industrial capitalist societies, and thus, an understanding of the connections between class and gender is essential to the effort to develop a theory of society that addresses the oppression of women and the privileging of men.¹ The search for a reconciliation between Marxist analyses of political-economic structure and feminist analyses of women's place dominates many of the discussions about gender and class.² Although these discussions have produced a vast and illuminating theoretical and em-

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¹Theories that do not adequately address the subordination of women and the privileging of men may also fail as comprehensive frameworks for understanding other phenomena. See, e.g., Rosemary Crompton and Michael Mann, eds., *Gender and Stratification* (Oxford: Basil Blackwood, 1986), which is an extended debate about whether concepts developed to analyze society as a whole are partial and misleading when they are insensitive to gender differences.

²This is evident in the wide array of literature cited in this essay. See Joan Acker, "Women and Stratification: A Review of Recent Literature," *Contemporary Sociology* 9, no. 1 (January 1980): 25–34.

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pirical literature, unresolved issues remain.³ This can best be illustrated with a brief review of the primary discussions.

The focus of the earliest such discussion was the unwaged housewife, whose labor was usually ignored in prefeminist theoretical discussions of capitalism. Unpaid domestic labor was brought into the light of theoretical scrutiny and recognized as essential to capitalism because it reproduces the working class and contributes to the reproduction of class relations and to the accumulation of capital.⁴ In these analyses women are inserted into the class structure by arguing that their unpaid labor is essential to meet needs of the capitalist system. However, as Maxine Molyneux points out, functional explanations do not tell us why it is women's unpaid labor that is necessary to the capitalist system nor do they describe the underlying social relations that shape women's unpaid work in the home.⁵ Another criticism of the domestic labor debate, as it has been called, is that it fails to give sufficient attention to women's paid work and to gender ideology. In short, to understand the ways in which capitalism benefits from an unpaid domestic labor force is not, necessarily, to understand the ties between class and gender.

In another approach, gender and class appear as two relatively autonomous systems of exploitation and oppression that affect women. Here, theories of patriarchy and capitalism attempt to locate the connections between class and gender in the historical development and ongoing reproduction of the subordinate position of women in both the paid and unpaid worlds of labor.⁶ Patriarchy or

³ See, e.g., Michele Barrett, *Women's Oppression Today* (London: Verso, 1980); Nancy Hartsock, *Money, Sex, and Power* (New York: Longman, 1983); Alison M. Jaggar, *Feminist Politics and Human Nature* (Totowa, N.J.: Rowman & Allanheld, 1983); Heidi Hartmann et al., *The Unhappy Marriage of Marxism and Feminism* (London: Pluto, 1981); Natalie Sokoloff, *Between Money and Love* (New York: Praeger, 1980).

⁴ For example, Wally Secombe, "The Housewife and Her Labour under Capitalism," *New Left Review*, no. 83 (January–February 1974), 3–24; Jean Gardiner, "Women's Domestic Labour," *New Left Review*, no. 89 (January–February 1975), 47–58; Bonnie Fox, ed., *Hidden in the Household* (Toronto: Woman's Press, 1980); Roberta Hamilton and Michele Barrett, eds., *The Politics of Diversity* (London: Verso, 1986).

⁵ Maxine Molyneux, "Beyond the Domestic Labour Debate," *New Left Review*, no. 116 (July–August 1979), 3–28. See also R. W. Connell, *Which Way Is Up: Essays on Class, Sex and Culture* (North Sydney: George Allen & Unwin, 1983). Veronica Beechey, in *Unequal Work* (London: Verso, 1987), summarizes the views of the critics of this approach.

⁶ For summaries and critiques, see Barrett; Zillah Eisenstein, ed., *Capitalist Patriarchy and the Case for Socialist Feminism* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 1979); Hartmann et al.; Sokoloff; and Jaggar.

the sex/gender system⁷ is analytically distinct from capitalism and its apparently gender-neutral class structure. The central conceptualization of class relations, that capitalists own the means of production and workers survive only by selling their labor power to these owners in an exchange that renders workers powerless and makes possible capital accumulation, does not distinguish between women and men as gendered subjects. Patriarchal processes in interaction with capitalist processes result in the particular oppression of women. In this approach, then, an analysis of women's class exploitation depends on a recognition of gender subordination. The class exploitation of men, in contrast, is assumed to be gender neutral.

Such an analytic framework posits man as the general human being and woman as the particular category, gender specified and other than the general.⁸ Gender is called upon to understand woman's fate, a particular destiny within the gender-neutral structure of capitalist processes. As illuminating as this work has been, much of it implicitly defines women as nonessential to developing an overall theory of society. Moreover, conceptual indifference to sexual differentiation can only reinforce the preexisting model of society built on the activities and consciousness of men alone. This model, therefore, is not gender neutral. Furthermore, as Iris Young argues,⁹ theories that construct patriarchy and capitalism as distinct systems ultimately leave the conventional analysis of class unaltered by locating the roots of women's oppression outside of class structure.¹⁰ Consequently, Marxist definitions of the social relations of class need to be reconsidered in order to formulate a theory of society that recognizes both class and gender as central.¹¹

⁷The term used by Gayle Rubin in "The Traffic in Women: Notes on the Political Economy of Sex," in *Towards an Anthropology of Women*, ed. Rayna Reiter (New York: Monthly Review Press, 1975).

⁸Nicole-Claude Mathieu, "Notes toward a Sociological Definition of Sex Categories," *International Journal of Sociology* 5 (Winter 1975-76): 14-38.

⁹Iris Young, "Beyond the Unhappy Marriage: A Critique of the Dual Systems Theory," in Hartmann et al.

¹⁰There are, of course, political reasons for wanting to develop a theory of capitalist patriarchy in which the central class/gender structure is understood as one system. Socialist movements have, in the past and today, often defined organizing around women's issues as disruptive or at least as a diversion of attention from the main contradiction, that of class. A theory that illuminates the central role of gender in systems of domination generally, not only in the subordination of women, should eventually help to make it easier for men and women to get together in political action. Young discusses this from an American point of view.

¹¹Hartsock, 149; and Jaggar, 161, make similar suggestions. Feminist concern with rethinking class coincides with other debates about how to conceptualize class while taking into account vast changes in the organization of work and production

Such a gender-integrated class analysis must provide a way of understanding the situation of the economically dependent housewife within the ongoing processes of class formation.¹² Dorothy Smith's proposal for building a sociology *for* women suggests starting from women's concrete experiences, recognizing differences in economic and cultural contexts, and then locating the processes through which these experiences come into existence in the social relations of the society as a whole.¹³ Feminist literature and research suggest the experience of economic dependence on a man as the starting point for understanding the class and gender processes that eventuate in the experiences of the economically dependent housewife.¹⁴

Family obligations that keep women out of the paid labor force for periods of time and the restricted opportunities and incomes available to many women when they do enter the paid labor force work in tandem to promote women's economic dependence. This situation of depending on a man, usually a husband, for survival is more than a residual effect of other processes, however, and cannot be fully understood with explanations focusing on a lack or absence—lack of job motivation because of family obligations or absence of opportunity because of discrimination or the structure of

in contemporary capitalist societies. See, e.g., David Plotke, "The United States in Transition: Toward a New Order?" *Socialist Review* 54 (November–December 1980): 71–124; Eric Olen Wright, *Class, Crisis and the State* (London: New Left Books, 1978).

¹² Empirical and theoretical studies provide a growing body of new knowledge on which to base a gender-integrated class analysis. See, e.g., studies of the persistence and re-creation of the sex-segregated labor force, Barbara F. Reskin and Heidi I. Hartmann, eds., *Women's Work, Men's Work: Sex Segregation on the Job* (Washington, D.C.: National Academy Press, 1986); for the history of working women, Alice Kessler-Harris, *Out to Work* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1982); for the development of the family wage, Hilary Land, "The Family Wage," *Feminist Review* 6 (1980): 55–77; and for the paid and unpaid work experiences of women, Ann Oakley, *The Sociology of Housework* (New York: Pantheon, 1974); and Ann Game and Rosemary Pringle, *Gender at Work* (London: Pluto Press, 1984).

¹³ Dorothy Smith, "Women's Perspective as a Radical Critique of Sociology," *Sociological Inquiry* 4 (January 1974): 7–13, "Some Implications of a Sociology of Women," in *Woman in a Man-made World: A Socioeconomic Handbook*, ed. Nona Glazer and Helen Waehrer, 2d ed. (Chicago: Rand McNally, 1977), and "A Sociology for Women," in *The Prism of Sex: Essays in the Sociology of Knowledge*, ed. Julia A. Sherman and Evelyn Torton Beck (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1979).

¹⁴ Economic dependence is recognized as fundamental to the powerlessness of women in this society by almost everyone who has written about the condition of women, from Kollontai (see Barbara Evans Clements, *Bolshevik Feminist: The Life of Alexandra Kollontai* [Bloomington: Indiana University Press, 1979]), to Simone de Beauvoir's *The Second Sex* (New York: Knopf, 1957), to the theorists of patriarchal capitalism (see Sokoloff [n. 3 above]).

the family and economy. It is a continuing experience, reproduced on a daily basis. Though the material conditions and the meaning of dependence vary widely according to the class situation of the husband, dependence is a core constituent of the reality of class in the lives of many women. The concrete social relations through which this dependence is produced have to do with the distribution of the family wage.¹⁵ The concept of distribution can also help us to understand other aspects of the development of differences in class situations.¹⁶

Reformulation of the Marxist definition of class to develop a gender-integrated analysis also requires a conceptualization of gender that posits only one structure. Studies of the labor process¹⁷ and of the intertwining of gender and technology in the restructuring of production¹⁸ are part of an emerging approach to unraveling how gender is implicated in the organization of production, the labor process, and the wage relation. These studies show how processes and relations are "gendered," how gender enters as a constitutive element¹⁹ in actions and ideas. The term "gendered" indicates that gender-based beliefs and images along with gender-based asymmetries in power and rewards mediate relations. This usage directs the analysis to gender as an integral part of all social existence in contrast to formulations of gender as analytically outside of other systems and impinging on those systems only at certain points.

¹⁵ Mary McIntosh, "The Welfare State and the Needs of the Dependent Family," in *Fit Work for Women*, ed. Sandra Burman (New York: St. Martin's, 1979); Barrett (n. 3 above), 135.

¹⁶ Marx (e.g., in "Introduction to a Critique of Political Economy," in Karl Marx and Frederick Engels, *The German Ideology* [New York: International Publishers, 1970]) saw distribution as subordinated to production. "The relations and modes of distribution are thus merely the reverse aspect of the factors of production. An individual whose participation in production takes the form of wage-labour will receive a share in the product, the result of production, in the form of wages. The structure of distribution is entirely determined by the structure of production" (Marx and Engels, 136). Further, he implicitly assumed that a discussion of interest, profit, rent, and wages exhausted the forms of distribution. "An individual who has neither capital nor landed property of his own is dependent on wage labour from his birth as a consequence of social distribution" (Marx and Engels, 136). To the extent that those outside the wage relation were discussed, at issue was their part in the system of production rather than how they obtained the means of survival.

¹⁷ For example, Evelyn Nakano Glenn and Roslyn L. Feldberg, "Degraded and Deskilled: The Proletarianization of Office Work," in *Studies in the Labor Process*, ed. A. Zimbalist (New York: Monthly Review Press, 1979); and David Knights and Hugh Willmott, *Gender and the Labour Process* (Aldershot, England: Gower, 1986).

¹⁸ For example, Cynthia Cockburn, *Machinery of Dominance* (London: Pluto, 1985).

¹⁹ Joan Scott, "Gender: A Useful Category of Historical Analysis," *American Historical Review* 91, no. 5 (December 1986): 1053–75.

In this paper, instead of positing two systems or sets of relations, I reformulate the concept of class²⁰ by expanding the definition of the relations that produce class and by arguing that these relations are gendered processes. I suggest that classes are structured through relations of distribution as well as relations of production. The wage, personal relations, and the state are all locations of gendered distribution in late capitalist societies.

The following discussion is based almost entirely on research about the United States and Great Britain, although studies of women's paid and unpaid work in some contemporary Third World countries suggest that this approach to understanding the intertwining of gender and class might be more widely applied.²¹

The social relations of distribution

Relations of distribution are sequences of linked actions through which people share the necessities of survival. Since all known societies organize daily activities on the basis of sexual divisions and celebrate gender differences in multiple symbolic ways, distribution, as a necessary part of daily life, is influenced by gender, and the relations through which subsistence resources are allocated are therefore infused with gender meanings.²² This is true in societies in which production and distribution are imbedded within kinship groups that at the same time define gender and bestow rights or entitlements to subsistence, as well as in societies where most production takes place outside the family or kin group and much of distribution is to individuals in the form of wages.

²⁰ Marxists vary in their definitions of class. The concept as articulated by E. P. Thompson in *The Making of the English Working Class* (New York: Vintage, 1963), and *The Poverty of Theory* (London: Merlin Press, 1978) seems most compatible with the feminist project. Class is a social-historical process in which "men and women, in determinant productive relations, identify their antagonistic interests, and come to struggle, to think, and to value in class ways. Thus, the process of class formation is a process of self-making, although under conditions which are 'given'" (Thompson, *The Making of the English Working Class*, 9). Those determinate relations of production are themselves the result of previous and ongoing processes of conflict and change. This view of class as process is also used by Rayna Rapp in "Family and Class in America," in *Rethinking the Family*, ed. Barrie Thorne (New York: Longman, 1982), 171.

²¹ See, in particular, Lourdes Beneria and Martha Roldan, *The Crossroads of Class and Gender* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1987).

²² When we include gender in the analysis of social relations, the distinction between meaning and action becomes only an analytic distinction. Gender divisions always involve socially constructed understandings. Symbol and act are integral to each other in the concept of gender.

The gendered relations of distribution in capitalist societies are rooted historically in the long process of the breakup of feudalism and the establishment of industrial capitalism. This transformation involved not only the emergence of new relations of production but also the disruption of old rights of entitlement and the attempt to institute universal market relations as the basis of distribution. The wage became the method by which the means of survival were distributed to the emerging working class, but wage labor was not available to everyone, nor was everyone able to work. Moreover, wage levels were often below subsistence levels—this was especially true for women—and working conditions undermined health and well-being. Thus, the centuries-long breakdown of the old distribution and entitlement system and its replacement by the wage labor system revealed a fundamental contradiction of capitalism, a contradiction between production and reproduction: the new economic system was indifferent to the reproduction of its own working class and the demands of working-class daily life.²³ While the unemployed and the excluded could be left to starve or forage on the fringes of the economy, those in power eventually saw that it was necessary to find other arrangements of distribution, often in response to organized worker demands for more adequate wages and welfare supports. Thus, through trade union conflict, political battles, and campaigns for social reform, old forms of entitlement were transformed into new relations of distribution that mediated the contradiction between production and reproduction and allowed the working-class family to survive.²⁴ These new relations depended on the family wage, its distribution from the male wage-earner and husband to the dependent housewife who kept family

²³ Among many others, Marx (*Capital* [New York: Modern Library, 1906]), drawing on contemporary government investigations, provides examples of the destruction of the health and well-being of men, women, and children caught in the system of wage work in nineteenth-century England. The situation in the United States may have been less extreme, although poverty rates were very high among American workers during the period of rapid industrialization at the end of the nineteenth and beginning of the twentieth centuries. This very short and summary description of the process leaves out important issues but is, I believe, generally correct. See Frances Fox Piven and Richard Cloward, *The New Class War* (New York: Pantheon, 1982), for similar views.

²⁴ Several recent articles use both U.S. and British materials to structure such historical accounts. See Gita Sen, "The Sexual Division of Labor and the Working-class Family: Towards a Conceptual Synthesis of Class Relations and the Subordination of Women," *Review of Radical Political Economics* 12, no. 2 (Summer 1980): 76–86; Johanna Brenner and Maria Ramas, "Rethinking Women's Oppression," *New Left Review*, no. 144 (March–April 1984), 33–71.

life going with her unpaid labor, and various kinds of state benefits to supplement the wage.²⁵

The wage

The wage is, of course, an essential component of the capitalist economic system and is *both* an aspect of production and a mechanism of distribution. It is the major way that production becomes the means of subsistence for the majority of adult males, and many adult females. At the same time, it is the wage relation that specifies the worker's connection to the means of production and to those who own and control industry and capital.²⁶ It is distinct from other forms of distribution because the wage is a market exchange, contractual in nature, and because it is the personal property of the worker, although for women the right to their own wage was established in law only in the mid-nineteenth century.²⁷

In its historical development and in its present form the wage is a gendered phenomenon, gendered for men as well as for women. That is, men's wages, in general, have always been and continue to be higher than women's wages in general.²⁸ The sex segregation of economic sectors, occupations, and work organizations is asso-

²⁵ I have also not dealt systematically with race in this paper, although the most serious inequalities in distribution are those based on both race and gender. An adequate attempt to include race would take more space, and probably a different analysis. I have also not dealt systematically with class differences between women only because there is too little space in one paper to include them.

²⁶ Recent studies of women workers in industrial home work in England by Sheila Allen, "Invisible Threads," *IDS Bulletin* 12, no. 3 (1981): 41–47; and in Mexico by Beneria and Roldan (n. 21 above), demonstrate that workers are tied to capital in other ways than the formal wage relation. Martha Roldan in "Industrial Outworking: Struggles for the Reproduction of Working-class Families and Gender Subordination," in *Beyond Employment: Household, Gender and Subsistence*, ed. Nanneke Redclift and Enzo Mingione (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1985), 254, argues that these range from forms resembling petty-commodity production, where workers own their own machines, to quasi-proletarianized work relations, where workers own nothing, are paid wages, but pay some costs of production by supplying their homes as the workplace. Women constitute almost all of these workers, and these forms of work are becoming more prevalent in advanced industrial countries. This form of work is not included in the present analysis, although it is clearly gendered and tends to be done by the poorest women.

²⁷ Leo Kanowitz, *Women and the Law* (Albuquerque: University of New Mexico Press, 1979).

²⁸ See, e.g., Ivy Pinchbeck, *Women Workers and the Industrial Revolution, 1750–1850* (London: Frank Cass, 1969); Harry Braverman, *Labor and Monopoly Capital* (New York: Monthly Review Press, 1974).

ciated with the wage gap, as is widely known.²⁹ Wage differences are justified by arguments pointing to invidious distinctions between the sexes. It is said that women eat less than men and thus need less, their work is less skilled and thus less valuable, women do not develop their human capital so their labor is less valuable, women need less because they do not have to support a family as men do. A male wage adequate to support a family has been explicitly supported since at least the middle of the nineteenth century by male-dominated trade unions and by social reformers who believe that industrial employment for women undermines the stability of the working-class family.³⁰ Some employers have also maintained that the practice of paying a wage to a good family man encourages stability in the male work force.³¹ This ideal has also, undoubtedly, been supported by mothers who preferred to work only in the home, if at all possible, in order to take care of their children.³² In the United States, some male workers and most middle-class business and professional men were able to achieve this goal during periods of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. Their success supported the argument that women need not and should not work for wages and that those who do work for money should never put the job ahead of family obligations. In practice, these ideas meant that a just wage for men was necessarily higher than a just wage for women. The wage gap, in other words, was essential to implementing the ideal of a family wage.

In its present form, the wage is gendered in another sense; the concrete relations of production as experienced in the process of work are permeated with the ongoing social construction of gender. Tasks and activities that actually produce the pay check at the end of the week or the month are gendered in both obvious and subtle

²⁹For example, see Heidi I. Hartmann, "Capitalism, Patriarchy, and Job Segregation by Sex," *Signs: Journal of Women in Culture and Society* 1, no. 3, pt. 2 (Spring 1976): 137–69; and Donald J. Treiman and Heidi I. Hartmann, eds., *Women, Work, and Wages* (Washington, D.C.: National Academy Press, 1981).

³⁰Land (n. 12 above).

³¹For example, Martha May, "The Historical Problem of the Family Wage: The Ford Motor Company and the Five Dollar Day," *Feminist Studies* 8 (Summer 1982): 399–424.

³²Louise Tilly and Joan Scott, *Women, Work and Family* (New York: Holt, Rinehart, & Winston, 1978). For arguments on this question, see Jane Humphries, "The Working-Class Family, Women's Liberation, and Class Struggle: The Case of Nineteenth-Century British History," *Review of Radical Political Economics* 9 (Fall 1977): 25–41; Sen (n. 24 above); Heidi I. Hartmann and Anne R. Markusen, "Contemporary Marxist Theory and Practice: A Feminist Critique," *Review of Political Economics* 12 (Summer 1980): 87–93.

ways. Gendering occurs in the sex segregation of jobs within work organizations that typically locates women in some jobs and men in others.³³ For example, study after study shows that blue-collar women work routine production line jobs while men maintain the machines.³⁴ Such a division of labor generates and reinforces the association of masculinity with mechanical and technical skills and the association of femininity with patience and selfless dedication to repetitive tasks. The linkage of masculinity with skill can, in turn, be an ideological weapon in the exclusion of women from male-dominated jobs.³⁵

The specific ways that work relations involve and reproduce gender undoubtedly differ with the content of work, its location in the organization of production, and class context. Intellectual work, for example, has often been characterized in gender-based oppositions such as hard and soft, rigorous and loose,³⁶ in contrast to the gender-based oppositions in manual labor such as strength and patience, courage and diligence, and mechanical aptitude and mechanical ineptness.

The hierarchical order of work organizations, with disproportionate numbers of women at the bottom and disproportionate numbers of men at the top, is also an expression of gender. This order preserves traditional power relations between women and men and confirms the symbolic association of masculinity with leadership and femininity with supportiveness. Gender is so deeply embedded in hierarchical structure that alteration of the gender order tends to threaten the hierarchy itself.³⁷ Wage differences are integral to hierarchies; entrenched hierarchies result in persistent wage differences between the sexes.³⁸

³³ William T. Bielby and James N. Baron, "A Woman's Place Is with Other Women: Sex Segregation within Organizations," in *Sex Segregation in the Workplace: Trends, Explanations, Remedies*, ed. B. F. Reskin (Washington, D.C.: National Academy Press, 1984).

³⁴ For example, Michel Crozier, *The Bureaucratic Phenomenon* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1964); Marja Lusa Honkasalo, "Dead-End-Views on Career Development and Life Situation of Women in the Electronics Industry," *Economic and Industrial Democracy* 3 (November 1982): 445–64.

³⁵ Cynthia Cockburn, *Brothers: Male Dominance and Technological Change* (London: Pluto, 1983); Game and Pringle (n. 12 above).

³⁶ For example, Jessie Bernard, "My Four Revolutions," in *Changing Women in a Changing Society*, ed. Joan Huber (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1973).

³⁷ Joan Acker, "Sex Bias in Job Evaluation: A Comparable Worth Issue," in *Ingredients for Women's Employment Policy*, ed. Christine Bose and Glenna Spitze (Albany: State University of New York Press, 1987), 183–96.

³⁸ Rosabeth Moss Kanter, *Men and Women of the Organization* (New York: Basic, 1977).

In sum, the wage and the work contexts within which it is earned are gendered in ways that re-create women's relative disadvantage, even as changes in the organization of the economy and new technology create new kinds of wage work for women.

Economic independence is impossible for most women under such conditions.³⁹ Many women experience the consequences of these structural conditions as personal failure. For example, in a study of middle-aged women, a number of those who had bravely set out to build new and independent lives found that they could get only low-paying clerical jobs.⁴⁰ Such jobs provided neither the money nor the respect these women needed. They also confronted an unexpected disrespect and invisibility that seriously undermined and discouraged their efforts toward economic independence. Depression and self-doubt, as well as a realistic appraisal of their chances, sent some back to relationships of dependence that they did not want. The gender-based structure of the wage reinforced a gender-based structure in the personal relations of distribution.

Personal relations of distribution

Marriage and kin relations provide the avenues for much of the distribution of the wage to the unwaged. Marriage laws, child welfare laws, and other welfare laws all prescribe and, to a degree, regulate distribution through personal ties. These relations are per-

³⁹The increase in women's labor force participation might suggest that women's economic dependence on men is disappearing. The proportion of women with some income increased dramatically from 55 percent in 1960 to 88 percent in 1982 (income includes transfers, interest and dividends, child support, private pensions, wages, and salaries. U.S. Bureau of the Census, *Current Population Reports*, Series P-60, 142, "Money Income of Households, Families, and Persons in the United States, 1982" [Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, 1983], 123-24). A better measure of economic independence would tap the ability to support oneself over a considerable period of time from one's own earnings. Data on continuity of labor force participation and patterns of part-time and full-time work in Phyllis Moen, "Continuities and Discontinuities in Women's Labor Force Activity," in *Life Course Dynamics: Trajectories and Transitions, 1968 to 1980*, ed. Glen H. Elder, Jr. (Ithaca, N.Y.: Cornell University Press, 1985), show that in a random sample of U.S. households, only 23 percent of wives and female family heads were employed full-time year-round for all years in the five-year period 1972-76. This finding suggests that less than one-fourth of American women could be considered completely economically independent during that period, leaving over three-fourths at least partially dependent on husbands, other individuals, or the state.

⁴⁰Joan Acker, Kate Barry, and Joke Esseveld, "Feminism, Female Friends and the Reconstruction of Intimacy," in *Research in the Interweave of Social Roles: Women and Men*, ed. Helena Lopata (Greenwich, Conn.: JAI Press, 1981), vol. 2.

sonal in the sense that the distribution occurs between related individuals, usually in contexts that include sex, love, commitment, or friendship. Such ties are not, however, personal in the sense of having significance only at the level of psychological process or family interaction. On the contrary, these relations constitute elements in the underlying social structure, linking individual experience to external, distant economic and political processes.

Gender is an organizing principle in these distributive arrangements; in combination, the sex-based division of labor and the ideology of the family wage require that it is the male wage that is distributed to the woman and through her and her labor to children and other dependents. Though this uncomplicated arrangement has never existed for many people, it is still enshrined in much of American family law and cultural notions about the family.⁴¹

Other systems of distribution through personal relations are prevalent in American society. Though they are not so clearly patterned by notions of male privilege nor so firmly institutionalized as the cultural ideal, they are clearly affected by both gender and class. The networks of nurturing and support among black working-class women are the most obvious example in the United States.⁴² These are avenues through which very scarce resources may be shared with people who have no access to institutionalized distribution channels, such as wage work or welfare. Although powerful traditions may encourage such sharing, it is also a survival strategy among the poor that is often maintained by women. Kinship networks allocate resources, and ensure survival, though the resources they share vary by class level⁴³ and economic changes—such as those that produce widespread unemployment—often provide the impetus to create new webs of support and mutual assistance.⁴⁴ Kin-based distribution also occurs among the affluent and in the upper class, where it contributes to the stability and reproduction of class.

In general, despite the variety of forms, personal relations of distribution rest upon the existence of the wage-based system. If the wage is cut off, for whatever reason, the existing personal relations of distribution are disrupted, destroyed, or profoundly altered. Although the money that is distributed comes primarily from

⁴¹ Lenore Weitzman, *The Marriage Contract* (New York: Free Press, 1981): 23–24.

⁴² Carol Stack, *All Our Kin: Strategies for Survival in a Black Community* (New York: Harper Colophon, 1974). See also Julia Brannen and Gail Wilson, eds., *Give and Take in Families: Studies in Resource Distribution* (London: Allen & Unwin, 1987).

⁴³ Rapp (n. 20 above).

⁴⁴ Brenda Cochrane, "The Impact of Unemployment on Women Workers: A Cross-Sectional and Case Analysis" (Ph.D. diss., University of Oregon, 1985).

the wage, the forms of personal distribution cannot be deduced from an analysis at an abstract level of the capitalist economy. Women and men create personal relations of distribution in their daily actions within specific cultural and economic contexts. These processes are historically created, often by people trying to resist and survive under economic conditions they cannot control. For example, the idea that a working-class woman and her children could be supported by a wage-earning man was uncommon in both the United States and England at the beginning of the nineteenth century, when most production was agricultural and women's work, whether paid or unpaid, was essential to family survival.⁴⁵ Economic support through the family wage, to the extent it was achieved for the working class, was the result of conflict, reform, resistance and accommodation occurring in political, trade union, legal, and familial arenas as people tried to cope with the destructive effects of capitalist development and secure for themselves and their families economic survival and a satisfying daily life.⁴⁶

In late twentieth-century industrial societies, the re-creation and transformation of personal distribution continues. Though the totally dependent housewife is now a minority, few married women escape some periods of economic dependence and the ideology of the male breadwinner and the housewife may persist even as the reality recedes.⁴⁷

Relations of distribution within marriage

The unwaged housewife usually must depend on her husband for economic support. A woman receives money from a man—he brings home his pay (or other income) or deposits it in a bank, gives her all of it or only doles out an allowance. However it is divided up, in the extreme and now atypical case in which he is the only breadwinner, the money is obtained by the man. His activities in the world of wage labor, the relations that constitute the process of his

⁴⁵ Pinchbeck (n. 28 above). There is a large and growing literature dealing with the history of the impact on women's lives and work of developing industrial capitalism, including the process through which emerged the culturally and historically specific figures of the woman as dependent housewife and the man as breadwinner (see, e.g., Tilly and Scott [n. 32 above]; Kessler-Harris [n. 12 above]; Sen [n. 24 above]).

⁴⁶ Sen; Michelle Barrett and Mary McIntosh, "The 'Family Wage': Some Problems for Sociologists and Feminists," *Capital and Class* (Summer 1980), 51–72; Land (n. 12 above); McIntosh (n. 15 above).

⁴⁷ Lydia Norris, "Constraints on Gender: The Family Wage, Social Security and the Labour Market: Reflections on Research in Hartlepool," *Work, Employment & Society* 1, no. 1 (1987): 85–105.

earning a living, are part of the social relations that distribute to the woman the necessities of physical and social survival. The transactions between the woman and her husband over money are the last link in a series of actions that determine that final action and have their origin in the wage relation. In this sense, then, the non-wage-earning woman participates in a social relation that originates in the relations of production. The economically dependent woman is outside that paid production process in that her labor is not directly exchanged for a wage, but her social existence is still, in some basic ways, determined by that process and by identifiable social relations that link her to the wage sector. Unwaged housewives do not directly assume the class position of their husbands, although their standard of living and the social expectations they face are obviously results of the husband's position. Rather, they are in different situations than their husbands within the same system of relations that constitute the wage and its distribution. Thus, the unwaged housewife lives within class processes but with different experiences in different activities than her husband.⁴⁸

Distributive relations within the family differ sharply from those in the labor market. The housewife does not exchange a specific amount of labor for a specific amount of money; no connection exists between monetary rewards and amount of work, skill, experience, or effort. Although husbands benefit from housewives' domestic work, greater or lesser benefit does not modify a husband's obligation to support, in contrast to the wage contract in which the obligation to pay usually dissolves when the worker does not work. Conversely, the housewife's obligation to work is not contingent on benefits from the husband and the husband's obligation to support is virtually unenforceable, reduced within marriage to whatever the husband chooses to give.⁴⁹

The marriage agreement contains elements of exchange and mutual obligation, but to focus only on the exchange, as in the analogy to the wage relation, is to miss its essence. The entitlement of the woman to support and of the man to certain services from her rests in the fact of relationship itself rather than in a principle of exchange and, as such, is similar to earlier forms of distribution in which the right to support rested in a relationship of entitlement, not of market exchange. The analogy to feudal relations is useful only in this sense. We might argue, as Weitzman does, that marriage "has not moved from status to contract. It has not changed from a relationship based on status—in which rights and obligations flow from one's

⁴⁸ Authors writing about the family wage as both historical fact and ideology make a similar point. See Sen; Barrett and McIntosh; Land.

⁴⁹ Weitzman (n. 41 above), 40.

position—to a contractual relationship in which rights and obligations are freely negotiated by both parties.” Instead, she continues, marriage is a status-contract; individuals enter marriage freely, as in contractual arrangements, but once in the relationship, its terms and conditions are prescribed by the state. Although the state does not attempt to enforce this contract within ongoing marriages, and is ineffective in enforcing support when marriages terminate, these obligations still constitute the underlying assumptions of marital responsibility in our society.⁵⁰ Still, there is more to this relationship than duties and obligations based on status, for marriage is the legitimate domain in which people are to ensure their own survival and that of their children. Marriage, and the family it is supposed to sustain, is defined as a cooperative venture in which people give without thought to return. At least, these are the ideological terms in which personal distribution forms are imbedded in our society. The relationship that confers entitlement is one of love, duty, and commitment, and the exchange of labor and money is accomplished within these supporting values.

The twentieth-century American emphasis on love as the basis of marriage tends to obscure the character of marriage as an integral part of the society's system of distribution, and the ideology of the married pair as a team of equals also hides the reality. In addition, the husband's pay legally belongs to him and appears to be produced only by him, even though the wife's domestic labor has contributed to his ability to work and in some cases to the work itself.⁵¹ The transmittal of part or all of the husband's pay to the wife appears as a relationship specific to the two people. Money is a personal issue addressed in the context of an intimate sexual relationship. Negotiation over the distribution of money is contradictory to the spirit of sharing, commitment, and sexual mutuality that many people expect to find in marriage. Thus, the question of how the society should provide for distribution is obscured as it is transformed into a problem of interpersonal conflict.

Women's unpaid reproductive work within the home is accomplished within the conditions set by these personal relations of distribution.⁵² This structural location of women's work has various

⁵⁰ Ibid., xix, 126–53.

⁵¹ The debate over the contribution of domestic labor to the reproduction of labor power and thus to its value has been of limited use in explaining women's position, as Molyneux has observed. Nevertheless, many women do provide services that are essential to their husband's functioning in the work world (Molyneux [n. 5 above]).

⁵² For a somewhat different interpretation of housework within a gender/class frame, see Heidi I. Hartmann, “The Family as the Locus of Gender, Class, and Political Struggle: The Example of Housework,” *Signs* 6, no. 3 (Spring 1981): 366–94.

consequences. For example, much of the content of the work is determined by the husband's wages and his class position. Moreover, in contrast to waged work, the actual tasks that women are to perform are not clearly defined, and the boundaries are, relative to paid work, unspecified. How much house cleaning discharges the moral duty of marriage? Diffuse demands come from multiple sources. It is not only the demands of the husband and his job that structure a woman's daily life, it is also the demands of school, the media, the retail system, health authorities. Standards of performance come not so much from husbands as from other sources, often obscure and difficult to identify, and are often enforced by women themselves. The work is continuous and involves emotional support, planning, and continual monitoring of others. These are the nurturing, caring activities that are essential to child development and adult contentment. A recognition is emerging in feminist thought that there is a "third and hidden division of caring labor in the alienated reproduction of human beings themselves."⁵³ Far from being simpleminded work, homemaking is one form of caring labor that involves both mental and manual activities and a high degree of autonomy in both planning and carrying out of tasks.

Although the contemporary full-time housewife must exert initiative and independence to fulfill her responsibilities, her effort gives no return in terms of control over her economic situation. This is inherent in her position as economically dependent. She interacts only with her husband in one area of the distribution sequence. She cannot exert control over his work and its conditions. What he does that eventually produces his pay occurs in an arena she does not enter. Or, if she enters, it is temporarily and under rigidly specified conditions. It is true that many working men have slight control over their fates as workers, but what control they have—and this varies greatly by industry, by occupation, and as a function of union and workplace organization—is immeasurably greater than the control of their unwaged wives. Women can exercise some control but only indirectly—by making sure that their husbands get the rest they need, a good diet, and clean clothes. Women, of course, try to enter their husband's work in other ways that might give them some greater measure of power over their own lives. They may do waged work to support their husband's education, discuss his career and work problems with him, and offer advice. They may do unpaid

⁵³ Hilary Rose, "Hand, Brain, and Heart: A Feminist Epistemology for the Natural Sciences," *Signs* 9, no. 1 (Autumn 1983): 73–90. See also Kari Waerness, "The Invisible Welfare State: Women's Work at Home," *Acta Sociologica* 12, suppl. (1978): 193–208.

work for their husbands, particularly if their husbands are businessmen, managers, or professionals. The measures that women can take to increase their control, and thus their power and security, in a structural situation in which they are able to exercise little initiative to determine their futures, undoubtedly vary by the man's and woman's class. At the same time, this situation of little power over their material existence constitutes part of these women's class experience.

Economic dependence is a way of naming a link in this specific system of distribution. Dependence can be conceptualized as part of the processes or relations that constitute the society as a whole, rather than as an aspect of family structure. Dependence experienced as fear, powerlessness, and loss of self is often the individual consequence of this system of distribution. Although some women may learn early in life that they must depend on a man, such dependence is often produced in adulthood and as a result of marriage under structural conditions of distribution that encourage withdrawal from the labor force or sporadic and part-time paid work. For example, in one study middle-aged women repeatedly said that "I am not the same person I was before I got married," meaning always that they had lost a capacity to function alone without fear. In their memories were images of themselves as young women traveling across the country alone, serving in the armed forces during World War II, experiencing great success in their jobs. In their present lives they had intense feelings of indecision, hesitation, and fear of being alone. The contrast between the two selves led to regret for the loss of the person they had been. Yet, most of them were proud of their achievements as mothers and managers of households, refusing to devalue this experience even though, while requiring ingenuity, energy, and initiative, it had, in effect, made them timid and unconfident outside of the family realm. Thus, the structural roots of women's ambivalence about their self-image are located in a societal arrangement that makes many women economically dependent on men.⁵⁴

State relations of distribution

State benefits or transfers to individuals and families are another significant type of distribution arrangement. Social welfare transfer payments are explicitly planned to substitute for wages or their distribution through the family when these avenues of distribution

⁵⁴ Acker, Barry, and Esseveld (n. 40 above).

are inadequate or unavailable. Such collapses and inadequacies are a normal part of the functioning of capitalism and outside the control of individuals; depressions, recessions, exploitative economic development, as well as accidental death, injury, and chronic illness are ordinary features of this kind of economy. Husbands desert wives and mothers cannot earn enough to support their children; neither the wage nor personal avenues of distribution are adequate to guarantee survival to individuals. The state ameliorates these conditions to preserve social stability and the status quo or administers concessions won by labor and other social movements.⁵⁵

However, the state helps to create the conditions it is then called on to remedy. As Wachtel and Sawers argue, "The state influences the processes by which people obtain income, and thereby structures the *pretax, preexpenditures income distribution*. . . . The government creates a redistributive function for itself by establishing the initial conditions that require a redistributive policy."⁵⁶ Law and legal precedent defining the positions of women and men in marriage have historically involved the state in the definition of the woman as an economic dependent and have been an important factor in creating unequal distribution. Governmental policies and practices that support both sexism and racism contribute to the unequal distribution of income between white males and minority men and all women, thus helping to create some of the conditions that welfare benefits are intended to alleviate. Many of the laws that explicitly acted against equality between men and women, such as protective labor laws that prohibited night work for women, have been repealed. But other laws reinforce income inequalities between women and men. For example, Reagan administration cutbacks in welfare programs affected the income earning opportunities of women and minority male professionals who had found career possibilities in government not available in the private sector. "Women administrators have been laid off at a rate of 150% higher than male administrators. Minorities in administrative positions have been laid off at a rate of 220% higher than non-minority employees in similar posi-

⁵⁵ See, e.g., Piven and Cloward, *The New Class War* (n. 23 above); and Frances Fox Piven and Richard Cloward, *Regulating the Poor* (New York: Pantheon, 1971). Welfare state benefits vary widely from country to country in benefit levels, eligibility requirements, and policy goals. This discussion focuses primarily on the United States. State distribution includes services such as medical care or day-care or subsidies for costs of housing or food, as well as a variety of other services. Here the focus is on money transfers.

⁵⁶ Howard M. Wachtel and Larry Sawers, "Government Spending and the Distribution of Income," in *The Poverty Establishment*, ed. Pamela Roby (Englewood Cliffs, N.J.: Prentice-Hall, 1974), 65.

tions.”⁵⁷ These same reforms also reduced the incomes of poor working women whose income supplements from Aid to Families with Dependent Children (AFDC) were eliminated.⁵⁸

The effects on poor working women of the restructuring of AFDC illustrates the gendered nature of social benefits.⁵⁹ The most important income transfer programs originated in concerns about replacing the family wage and were significantly influenced by often hidden assumptions about the normality of the breadwinner-husband and dependent-housewife family. The family wage might need to be replaced because the breadwinner was dead or absent or because his income had been cut off. Responding to these different problems, some programs emerged with an implicit focus on women while others developed with an implicit focus on men, although both women and men are now eligible for all transfer programs except those that are explicitly related to childbearing.

Programs directed to women are linked to marital and parental status. Some benefits are explicitly for women as childbearers, others go primarily to women because they are the caretakers of children and do not have a man who is able to provide support. In addition to the absence of a provider, eligibility is based on a calculation of need, or a means test. Thus, poverty is a main criterion for benefits. The primary example of such a program, AFDC, originated in the Mother's Pensions movement of the early twentieth century that sought to provide support to worthy but impoverished widows with young children. Originators of these programs explicitly argued that the state should step in as the absent father, thus keeping intact the gendered power structure of the family.⁶⁰

The state still takes the role of the absent father in the Aid to Families with Dependent Children program in which female recipients far outnumber males. One indicator of this is that, in 1982,

⁵⁷ Augustus F. Hawkins, "Minorities and Unemployment," in *What Reagan Is Doing to Us*, ed. Alan Gartner, Colin Greer, and Frank Riessman (New York: Harper & Row, 1982), 134, as quoted in Zillah R. Eisenstein, "The Patriarchal Relations of the Reagan State," *Signs* 10, no. 2 (Winter 1984): 329–37.

⁵⁸ Deborah K. Zinn and Rosemary C. Sarri, "Turning Back the Clock on Public Welfare," *Signs* 10, no. 2 (Winter 1984): 355–70.

⁵⁹ Many of these arguments are also made by Diana M. Pearce, "Toil and Trouble: Women Workers and Unemployment Compensation," *Signs* 10, no. 3 (Spring 1985): 439–59; Elizabeth Wilson, *Women and the Welfare State* (London: Tavistock, 1977); and Barbara J. Nelson, "Women's Poverty and Women's Citizenship: Some Political Consequences of Economic Marginality," *Signs* 10, no. 2 (Winter 1984): 209–31.

⁶⁰ A large literature exists on history of the welfare state. See, e.g., Samuel Mencher, *Poor Law to Poverty Program* (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 1967). For an account of the mother's pension movement, see, e.g., John Lewis Gillin, *Poverty and Dependency* (New York: Appleton-Century, 1937).

98.7 percent of the children receiving benefits were in families with an absent father.⁶¹ Although it is publicly visible, AFDC is a very small part of the U.S. welfare state compared with programs implicitly directed to men.

Male-directed programs link benefits to wages or to military service rather than to mothering. This happens in two ways: first, some period of paid employment or service in the military is necessary to qualify and, second, the amount of the transfer is often linked to past earnings. Eligibility is based on the existence of some condition that prevents paid work—industrial or military injury, unemployment, old age—in contrast to the needs-based eligibility of female-directed benefits. Since men are more often wage earners or soldiers than are women, they are more likely to receive these transfers. For example, 10,045,000 men received veteran's benefits, unemployment compensation, or workers' compensation in 1983, while a little over half as many women, 5,159,000, received one or more of these income transfers.⁶² In addition, income-linked benefits to men are likely to be higher than income-linked benefits to women. In 1983, the median annual benefits to men from these three programs totaled \$13,056, while median annual benefits to women totaled \$7,792.⁶³

Social Security (Old Age, Survivors, and Disability Insurance), the largest U.S. transfer program, is another wage-based program, originally designed with the full-time, life-long worker, usually a male, in mind. With benefits based on earnings and length of time in covered employment, only the life-long worker could get maximum payments. Amendments to the Social Security Act provided for dependent wives and widows of insured workers. This works against the relative interests of employed married women who are eligible for either their own or the wife benefit, whichever is higher. Since the added benefit from working is usually slight, the married woman is likely to gain little at retirement from working and paying taxes.⁶⁴ While this Social Security provision recognizes the needs of the dependent housewife, it also reveals the underlying assumptions about a form of the family predicated on the economic dependence of women.

⁶¹ Bureau of the Census, *Statistical Abstract of the United States: 1985* (Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, 1984).

⁶² U.S. Bureau of the Census, *Current Population Reports*, Series P-60, no. 146, "Money, Income of Households, Families, and Persons in the United States, 1983" (Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, 1985), 172–75.

⁶³ Ibid.

⁶⁴ Martha Derthick, *Policymaking for Social Security* (Washington, D.C.: Brookings, 1979).

Some of the rules that have worked to women's disadvantage in the United States have changed recently as a result of efforts against sex discrimination. For example, wives' retirement benefits under Social Security were, for many years, denied to divorced women unless they had been married over twenty years to the retired worker. Now, women need to have been married only ten years before a divorce in order to qualify. Though such changes are important to individual women, it is not the differential awarding of benefits, *per se*, that disadvantages women as a group. The underlying reality of interrupted paid work and low wages for women will keep benefits to women at lower levels than benefits to men, as long as those benefits are linked to wages.

Although most U.S. income transfer programs are rooted in assumptions about traditional gender relations, the experience of receiving state support may undermine those relations by opening for women areas of autonomy, free from direct subordination to a man. One British study shows that some women who receive public assistance after a husband's departure feel an increased sense of independence and control that compensates for a reduction in income.⁶⁵ This counters some feminist analyses that the state reinforces traditional female dependency in the process of giving aid. The degree to which state personnel invade the personal privacy of recipients is probably important in shaping the gendered meaning of receiving state benefits.

The benefits of the welfare state are social relations of economic distribution comparable to those of personal relations of distribution. A Social Security transfer, for example, involves relations between the recipient, the Social Security Administration, the Internal Revenue Service, the employer, the worker, the work, and, ultimately, the worker's wages. As in the case of husband and wife, the interaction between a recipient and a government employee over eligibility is only the last link in a series of actions and transactions that result in a transfer of money from one to another. The computerization of this relation masks but does not alter its nature. The state mediates the relation between the wage earner and the recipient, determining the amount of the benefit, its form, and what the recipient must do in order to receive support.

Invasion of personal life is minimal in wage-related transfers because individual need does not have to be proved. Although these transfers are called insurance—unemployment insurance, old age insurance—state insurance benefits are not exchanges in which peo-

⁶⁵ Hilary Graham, "Being Poor: Perceptions and Coping Strategies of Lone Mothers," in Brannen and Wilson, eds. (n. 42 above).

ple get exactly that for which they have previously paid. Frequently, they get more than they have paid.⁶⁶ Such benefits are entitlements based on status, such as worker or soldier, and physical characteristics that define certain categories as deserving of subsistence. These are politically created categories, formed through legislative responses to demands of political constituencies.

A comparison of the sources of income of solo mothers in the United States, Britain, and Sweden in the mid-1970s illustrates how similar groups fare differently, probably as the result of governmental policy strongly affected by the presence or absence of powerful labor parties.⁶⁷ In families headed by working solo mothers, the woman's earnings contributed 51 percent of family income in the United States and Britain and 58 percent in Sweden. "In Sweden virtually all such families receive government transfers; 85 percent of the British solo mothers receive government transfers. In the United States the proportion is 58 percent." However, in the United States, solo mothers who receive state benefits are more dependent on these government transfers than are their counterparts in Britain and Sweden. American solo mothers' beneficiaries counted on transfers for 40 percent of their family income, while British mothers received 32 percent of their income and Swedish mothers received only 16 percent of their income in this way.⁶⁸

These differences are almost certainly due to government policy. In Sweden, for example, all parents receive a child allowance and municipalities have the obligation to pay child support if the absent parent fails to provide it. In addition, a full employment policy guarantees some sort of job to almost everyone who is able to work, and trade union efforts have lessened the wage gap between women and men. Swedish solo mothers are entitled to government transfers both because they are parents and because they are parents alone; they do not have to demonstrate financial need. In contrast, in the United States, solo mothers usually, with the exception of widows who receive survivor's benefits under Social Security, receive government transfers only when they can demonstrate financial need. Thus, in the United States those who receive welfare benefits constitute a smaller and more impoverished group than those in Sweden.

This contrast between Sweden and the United States is also an example of the way in which capitalist distribution systems with basically the same components, but with different allocations of political power between capital and labor, can have different out-

⁶⁶ Derthick, 6.

⁶⁷ Lee Rainwater, "Mother's Contributions to the Family Money Economy in Europe and the United States," *Journal of Family History* (Summer 1979), 197–211.

⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, 203.

comes for groups in similar structural positions—in this case solo mothers. Their families have low incomes in both countries, but in Sweden social benefits protect single mothers from the absolute poverty facing so many women in the United States.⁶⁹

Gender, distribution, and class structure

What are the implications for the understanding of class structure and class formation if distribution is added to the conceptualization of class relations? Class structure is more complex when seen as structured through gendered distribution *and* the gendered relations of production than when it is conceptualized as emerging only from production. This does not obviate the notion that underlying relations of exploitation mark the division between capitalist and worker or the idea that processes of capital accumulation are constantly restructuring the way the wage can be obtained. However, culture and politics help to shape these processes, most often through conflict over distribution, producing a class structure with multiple divisions that arise from different mixes of gendered distributional relations. While concepts of working class, middle strata, and capitalist class still refer to recognizable societal divisions, they are concepts that must be redefined and considerably elaborated if they are to continue to be useful in comprehending the entirety of contemporary societies. An understanding of distribution as a gendered process assumes that those outside the wage relation have definite locations within the class structure.

These locations are not determined spaces within class boundaries but patterns of participation in production, reproduction, and distribution that vary between women and between men as well as over a lifetime. These patterns, extending over time, are part of struggles for subsistence and survival and constitute some of the differences between men and women in their situations in a changing class structure. In some cases different combinations of distribution patterns may create distinct classes. For example, in the United States, it is possible, although perhaps not adequate, to talk about impoverished single mothers as part of an underclass. In Sweden, in contrast, such women are not identifiable as members of an outcast class because, like almost everyone else, they work, receive social benefits, and sometimes get a bit of support from

⁶⁹ Diana Pearce and Harriette McAdoo, *Women and Children: Alone and in Poverty* (Washington, D.C.: Catholic University Law School, Center for National Policy Review, 1982).

relatives and friends. Thus, distribution helps us to comprehend differences between the class structures of advanced capitalist countries.

The primary aim of class analysis is not to define bounded categories into which people fit, but to comprehend class formation, the processes that produce contradiction, conflict, coalition, and different life experiences. The formation of self-conscious classes has occurred primarily through conflicts over distribution, not through conflicts over the control of production. This is not to ignore important efforts to resist new technology and employer controls but, rather, to recognize that much of the resistance to emerging industrial capitalism arose as protest over a new system of distribution—the wage—that left many people hungry. Labor struggles were, and still are, struggles for jobs and higher wages.

Contemporary changes in technology and the organization of production are altering class structure, traditionally conceived, and are undermining established modes of distribution for particular sectors of the population, while other sectors prosper. These changes can be analyzed as a growing crisis of distribution in all late industrial capitalist societies. In the United States, the crisis is signaled by an apparent decline in the strength of distribution from men to women and the increasing poverty of women and children, the massive elimination of high-paying, male, working-class jobs, and the introduction of new, low-paying, female jobs, particularly in service work.⁷⁰ If computerization in the office continues to slow the growth of clerical work, as recent projections indicate, the crisis of distribution will increase, as new clerical jobs will be insufficient to replace lost industrial work.⁷¹

In order to strengthen the theoretical links between gender and class, the conceptualization of the social relations that underlie class divisions must be changed. One way to do this is to see class as rooted in relations of distribution (as well as in relations of production) that necessarily embed gender, both as ideology and material inequality. The wage, welfare state benefits, and personal relations of distribution are interconnected processes that distribute the means of survival to most people in industrial capitalist societies. The wage is a component of both relations of production and distribution; other relations of distribution have developed histor-

⁷⁰ Richard Corrigan, "No Smoke, No Growth?" *National Journal* (July 27, 1985), 1732–36.

⁷¹ Bruce Stokes, "Beaming Jobs Overseas," *National Journal* (July 27, 1985), 1726–31; U.S. Congress, Office of Technology Assessment, *Automation of American Offices* (Washington, D.C.: Government Printing Office, OTA-CIT-287, December 1985).

ically, based on older principles of entitlement, as people tried to find ways to live in an economy focused on profit rather than on human needs.

Gender distinctions are built into the organization of paid work, just as they are built into eligibility for public transfers and marital support obligations. At the same time, relations of distribution embody and perpetuate male dominance and the subordination of women. The increased employment rates of women alter but do not fundamentally change these underlying relations. Indeed economic independence from men may only change the nature of vulnerability for those women who can get only low-income and unstable work.

Relations of distribution as well as relations of production constitute the grounds for class divisions in the wage-labor system. Nearly all men are wage or salary earners, but what they do to earn money, how much they earn, and the power they exert in the process markedly differentiates working-class men, middle-class men, and ruling-class men. For women, too, class boundaries are delineated by differences in the process of earning a wage. However, women's class experience is shaped by other, additional, relations of distribution. There is a vast distance between the lawyer who decides to stay at home for awhile with her baby and the woman on AFDC in Harlem; that distance has to do with gender, race, and distribution as much as it has to do with production.

In the absence of a new and more fitting term, I propose that we begin to talk about the gender/class structure as a process in which women and men, in determinant relations of production and distribution, identify their antagonistic interests, and come to struggle, to think, and to value in gender/class ways (to paraphrase E. P. Thompson).⁷² Perhaps with such a discussion we can reinterpret the history of specific industrial capitalist societies in terms of their gender/class structures, to see more clearly the part that gender takes in structuring relations between classes and promoting compelling systems of belief that justify and perpetuate domination.

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⁷² Thompson, *The Making of the English Working Class* (n. 20 above), 9.